



- Place an apostrophe where letters have been **omitted**. This is not always where the words have joined.
- Another way to form the **possessive of a noun** is to swap the position of the owner and the item it owns and connect them with the word *of*. For example, instead of writing “the Netherlands’s tulips,” write “the tulips **of** the Netherlands.”

Apostrophes frequently appear in non-English **surnames**, such as **O’Neill**, **N’Dor**, and **D’Agostino**.

Forming the possessive

An apostrophe marks a noun’s possession (ownership) of something. There are two forms of possessive apostrophes. The first, an apostrophe followed by an *s* (-’s), shows possession of a singular noun. The second, an apostrophe after the *s* (-s’), shows possession of a plural noun ending in *s*.

play’s new director

The new director belongs to the play, which is singular.

To form the possessive of a singular noun, add an apostrophe, followed by the letter *s*.

grapes’ seeds

When forming the possessive of a plural that ends in *s*, only an apostrophe is added.

The seeds belong to *grapes*, which is plural.

women’s story
people’s faces

If a plural word ends in any letter other than *s*, such as *e*, *i* or *n*, an apostrophe is added, followed by the letter *s*.

play’s new director had spelled
Socrates’s revised script.

Words ending in *s*

In the past, some grammar styles have recommended that the possessive of a proper noun ending in *s* be written with only an apostrophe, and no additional *s*. Today, an *s* is generally added in all cases.

The possessive of *Socrates* is *Socrates’s* rather than *Socrates’*.

Socrates’s
revised script

The possessive of *Jess* is *Jess’s* rather than *Jess’*.

Jess’s
disbelief

GLOSSARY

Auxiliary verb A “helping” verb that is used with other words to form contractions.

Contraction A shortened form of a word or words, in which letters are omitted from the middle and replaced with an apostrophe.